



From: Grandma Rose

A Sunday Morning in October

My dearest Emma,

I found myself thinking of you this morning as I watched the sun rise over the garden. The roses you planted last spring have bloomed beautifully - deep crimson, just like you said they would be. You always did have better instincts for growing things than I ever had.

I know these past months have been difficult for you. Moving to a new city, starting that new job, being so far from home. I want you to know that I'm **so proud** of how brave you've been. Courage isn't the absence of fear, sweetheart - it's doing what needs to be done even when you're afraid.

Do you remember when you were seven, and you were so nervous about your first piano recital? You told me you couldn't do it, that you'd forget all the notes. But I told you that even if you made mistakes, what mattered was that you

tried. You played beautifully that day - not perfectly, but beautifully. There's a difference.

Life is like that piano recital, Emma. None of us play it perfectly. We all hit wrong notes. We all stumble. But the music is in the trying, in the showing up, in the continuing even when our hands shake.

I know you feel lonely sometimes in that big city. I know your apartment feels empty after a long day, and I know you miss your friends and family. Those feelings are valid, and it's okay to sit with them for a while. But don't let them convince you that you made the wrong choice.

You are exactly where you need to be, doing exactly what you need to do.

Some of my fondest memories are from the years when I felt most lost. Strange, isn't it? But it's true. Those uncertain times, when I didn't know what came next, when I had to trust in myself and take risks - those are the times that shaped me, that made me who I am today.

Your grandfather used to say that comfort is the enemy of growth. I didn't understand what he meant for years, but now I see it clearly. You're growing, my love. And growth, real growth, is almost never comfortable.

You are stronger than you know.

You are braver than you feel.

You are loved more than you can imagine.

I'm enclosing your grandmother's bracelet - the silver one with the tiny compass charm. She gave it to me when I left home at your age, and her mother gave it to her. It's been in our family for four generations now. I want you to have it.

Whenever you feel lost, look at that compass and remember: sometimes being lost is just another word for finding a new way home.

Write to me when you can. Tell me about your days, your dreams, your difficulties. I want to hear it all. And remember that you can always come back to visit. Your room is exactly as you left it, and the door is always open.

The garden misses you. The roses miss you. But most of all, I miss you.

Keep blooming, my beautiful girl, even when you're planted in unfamiliar soil. Especially then.

All my love,
Always and forever,